farming" (natural farming with minimal intervention). The model works best for families seeking seasonal, nutrition-dense food. Gaddam of Polam Farms says, "During the Covid pandemic, we had an abundance of seasonal fruits and vegetables that we shared with others." Gaddam suggests that 1-2 acres is adequate to meet the yearly fruit and vegetable requirement of a five-member family. If crops such as wheat and maize are of interest, 3-5 acres may be necessary. "While small farms are more manageable, larger ones tend to yield profits as there is enough produce and also space for various activities," she explains.

While permaculture farms do generate enough produce for sustenance, generating a regular income is not easy. Many families pivot towards crafting experiential opportunities, such as farmstays, permaculture design courses, weekend workshops and value-added products to generate revenue. Gupta has created byte-sized online learning modules, each lasting 1-2 hours, covering subjects like permaculture introductions, rainwater harvesting for landscapes, and sustainable habitat creation. Solanki conducts residential workshops on similar topics at her Open Shell Farm. Establishments like Polam Stays and Tieedi also curate yoga and spiritual retreats, while showcasing a variety of their organic products such as jams, preserves and pickles for sale.

In 2006, Krishna McKenzie of Solitude Farm introduced a farm-to-plate cafe offering local cuisine from the 250 varieties of fruits, vegetables, grains, rice and edible weeds cultivated in his six-acre food forest in Tamil Nadu's Auroville. Additionally, his farm also offers volunteering opportunities. "Learning isn't only limited to formal interventions, it also happens when people volunteer on the farm or just visit the cafe to enjoy local delicacies," he says. He now invites artistes and bands to perform at the farm and is himself part of an Indo-acoustic pop band, Emergence.



SANDEEP SAHDEV

AANANDAA PERMACULTURE FARM

MANISHA LATH GUPTA, 51

IN A FORMER LIFE: Ex-CMO, Uber/Axis Bank

Where: 12-acre food forest in Boonga, Haryana

Motivation: "We used to live in Mumbai and read about the deteriorating quality of food and the looming water crisis. Every summer, there would be news about how Virar Lake had water left for only 5-7 days. People normally think of financial security for their kids. But money can't buy you clean water, food and air. We wanted to give our kids ecological security"

Revenue stream: Online courses, farmstays/ tours, organic produce market

THE MAINSTREAM HURDLE

Permaculture, as a concept, remains a niche trend limited to the urban elite for now. "Only those who have the capacity to take financial risks are adopting the permaculture life now. Farmers are usually busy making ends meet and don't have the mindspace to think about alternative living," says Dr Koppula. Starting a permaculture farm also requires a gestation period of at least 3-4 years as the land needs to regenerate from the ills of monocropping. "Unfortunately, not many can afford this," says Col. (retd) Vinay Nagyal, who is currently establishing a permaculture farm in Morni Hills near Chandigarh. In addition to the huge initial investment required to purchase land, funds are required for fencing, building water sources (rainwater harvesting structures or borewell) and constructing residential structures. But once up and running, permaculture farms are self-sufficient, demanding little operational expense other than during the sowing or harvesting seasons.

Dr Koppula says permaculture's design principles are universal and can be applied to any place anywhere. And he has proved it with his own farm and by his pioneering efforts in turning many wastelands in the arid Deccan plateau of Telangana and Andhra Pradesh into productive food forests. But that work is just one man's crusade and India will need thousands of Koppulas for permaculture to attain some level of criticality as an alternative for our farmers. For now, it is still a 'healthy lifestyle choice' for those who feel the need and, more importantly, have the means to turn their back on the urban city's promises. The true revolution is still in gestation. ■